

Design Guidelines

Architectural & Exterior Standards

The Villas at Worthington Homeowners Association, Inc.

North Royalton, Cuyahoga County, Ohio

Current Revision: 2026 (previous revision: March 2017)

These Design Guidelines are a supplementary document and are intended to provide specific architectural and maintenance standards for the community. They are not fully inclusive and do not replace the primary governing documents of the Villas at Worthington Homeowners Association. These Guidelines address architecture, exterior appearance, and property maintenance only. Matters of use and conduct (such as pets, parking, trash, noise, and seasonal decorations) are addressed in the Association's separate Rules & Regulations, and certain restrictions are set by the Declaration. Where this document references such a topic, it points to where that topic is governed.

1. General Guidelines Applicable to All Homes

House Placement and Yard Grading

All dwelling units must conform to existing grade and drainage patterns.

Builders are responsible for regrading the lot to meet the approved drainage plan.

Preserve natural woods where practical.

Home Placement Rules

A minimum of one different house type elevation must separate identical models side by side.

Identical elevations are allowed across the street or at intersecting lot lines.

On a cul-de-sac, adjacent homes cannot share the same elevation.

2. Dwelling Type and Size

Permitted Dwelling Types

One-story homes with or without a basement.

Story-and-a-half or Cape Cod homes (upper level within roof gables with dormers).

Two-story homes with or without a basement.

Minimum Sizes

1,200 sq. ft. for one-story dwellings.

1,300 sq. ft. for two-story dwellings.

Minor variances up to 10% below minimum size requirements may be permitted at the Board's discretion based on lot size and neighborhood character.

3. Roof and Garages

Roofs

Dwelling roof and gable pitch: Minimum 6:12.

Porch/patio roof pitch: Minimum 3.5:12.

All shingles must be a uniform color.

Garages

Attached two-car minimum garages required for new construction.

4. Yards, Driveways, and Walks

Landscaping

Front yards must be landscaped within 90 days of occupancy (weather permitting).

Rear yards extend behind the rear elevation to the property lines.

Driveways and Walks

Permitted materials include:

Concrete (plain or decorative)

Brick, concrete, or stone pavers

Restrictions:

Gravel, dirt, or asphalt driveways are not permitted.

Driveways must not extend beyond front elevation into side lot areas.

Setbacks: At least 2 feet from lot lines; walks must be within 6 feet of dwelling side.

5. Color Schemes and Exterior Finishes

Siding Colors

No two adjacent homes may have the same siding color.

Allowed on opposite sides of street or intersecting lot lines.

Cul-de-sacs may have intersecting homes with same color.

Vinyl siding colors must be approved with submitted sample.

Trim, Shutters, Doors

Uniform trim color on all architectural elements of a single home.

Door and shutter colors must be from the following color families in relation to the main siding color:

Neutral colors (white, black, gray, beige, or brown)

Colors from the same palette as the siding but in a contrasting shade

Traditional accent colors appropriate to the architectural style of the home

Colors matching other architectural elements of the home, such as stone or brick accents

Stone and Masonry Finishes

Stone, brick, and other masonry elements are permitted in colors that complement the home's overall design scheme.

No specific restrictions on stone or brick colors as long as the general siding color rules are followed.

Masonry elements should be consistently applied across all visible elevations of the structure where used as a design feature.

Transitions between siding and masonry materials should occur at inside corners where possible, rather than mid-wall.

6. Prohibited Structures and Exterior Modifications

New Construction Restrictions

Underground homes and log homes are prohibited.

Exterior Modifications

No porches, additions, or appendages unless matching original home in material, style, and color.

Must be fully integrated into home design.

Above-grade structures must be enclosed to grade.

Storage Restrictions

Front porches may only contain standard porch furniture.

No visible exterior carpet from the street.

Front-facing trash and recycling bin storage enclosures are permitted if they meet the following:

Located immediately outside the garage or along the driveway side of the home, but not projecting forward of the main front elevation line of the garage.

Must be fully enclosed within a structure no larger than 4 feet high, 4 feet wide, and 3 feet deep.

Materials must match or complement the home exterior (e.g., neutral siding or painted wood).

Pets and Animals

The keeping of animals is a use restriction, not an architectural standard. It is governed by Section 9.1.7 of the Declaration and by the Association's Rules & Regulations, not by these Design Guidelines.

7. Outdoor Equipment and Fixtures

Railings

Must be wood, composite, or wrought iron look in a complementary color.

Solar Panels

In accordance with Ohio Revised Code § 5312.16, homeowners have the right to install solar panels.

While the HOA Board may establish reasonable guidelines regarding the placement of solar energy systems, it cannot prohibit them outright or impose restrictions that significantly increase the cost or decrease the efficiency of the system.

Homeowners planning to install solar panels must submit detailed plans including:

Panel specifications

Installation method

Placement location

Visual impact mitigation measures, which may include:

Low-profile mounting systems

Panel placement that aligns with roof planes where technically feasible

Color-coordinated components and frames when available without significant cost increase

Chimneys

Metal flues must be enclosed.

Direct-vent chimneys must vent to rear or side.

Water Discharge

Must comply with the subdivision's approved drainage and city regulations.

Skylights

Permitted on rear-facing roofs.

Other placements may be approved for contemporary designs.

8. Pools, Spas, and Play Equipment

Pools

Only in-ground pools are permitted (no above-ground or semi-in-ground pools).

Kiddie pools (temporary) allowed up to 72 hours.

In-ground pools must:

Be approved by Board.

Be at least 10 feet from any property line.

Not obstruct surface water flow.

Include screening (landscaping/decking).

Be fenced per city code and Section 11 of these guidelines; fencing must not attach to pool.

Hot Tubs/Spas

Hot tubs and spas are permitted in the rear yard.

Units may be in-ground, or above ground if incorporated into a deck, consistent with the Declaration. A standalone above-ground hot tub or spa not incorporated into a deck is not permitted.

All hot tubs and spas must be screened using fencing, landscaping, or another board-approved method to reduce visibility from the street and adjacent lots.

Units must comply with side and rear setback requirements.

Play Equipment

All play equipment must be placed in the rear yard.

Equipment must not violate property setback lines.

Equipment must be constructed of wood or painted/stained in natural tones (gray/brown/white).

Deck integration is permitted but not required.

Equipment must be properly maintained and in good condition.

Basketball Hoops

All basketball hoops (fixed or portable) must have a clear, professional-style backboard and be maintained in good condition.

Goals must not be attached to the dwelling or garage.

Placement must be behind the front elevation of the house or, in the case of corner lots, at least 15 feet from the street-side setback.

Broken or damaged goals must be repaired or removed promptly.

Portable hoops do not need to be put away after use but must follow all placement and maintenance rules.

9. Outbuildings and Storage Structures

Sheds and Pool Pump Buildings

Sheds allowed up to 160 sq. ft. and 10 ft. in height, subject to City of North Royalton zoning limits, which control if more restrictive (per Section 9.1.1 of the Declaration).

Must match house exterior with the following specific requirements:

Roof pitch must be at least 4:12

Roofing shingles must be identical in color and style to the main house

Siding material must be the same type and color as the main house

Trim color must be the same as the main house trim

Must be on a concrete pad and 10 feet from any property line.

10. HVAC and Utilities

AC Units and Heat Pumps

Must be placed in side or rear yard.

Screening of AC units and heat pumps is encouraged but not required. If homeowners choose to screen their units, recommended methods include:

Landscaping that is at least the height of the unit

Fencing or lattice that matches or complements the home's exterior

Manufactured HVAC screens designed for this purpose

Units should be maintained in good working order and kept free of excessive rust or deterioration visible from neighboring properties.

11. Fencing

Permitted Styles

No chain link fences.

Allowed only in rear yard.

Split rail (2–3 rail, up to 5') with optional dog wire.

Vinyl, PVC, or aluminum picket fences (max 4').

Wood, vinyl, or PVC privacy fences (max 6').

Setback & Variance

No fences within street-side setback (corner lots).

Up to 4' extension from side of home allowed for side-door access.

Pool fencing must meet city code (cross-reference with Section 8 pool requirements).

Approval Criteria

The Board will evaluate fence approval requests based on the following specific criteria:

Compliance with material, style, and height requirements

Appropriate placement within authorized areas

Quality of materials and professional installation plan

Impact on drainage and utility easements

Visual cohesiveness with surrounding properties

Maintenance

All fences must be maintained in good repair, structurally sound, and in a condition consistent with their original appearance, including repainting, re-staining, or repair of damaged sections as needed.

12. Antennas, Satellite Dishes, and Communications Equipment

Protected Communications Equipment

In accordance with the FCC's Over-the-Air Reception Devices (OTARD) Rule, homeowners have the right to install:

Satellite dishes $\leq$ 1 meter diameter

TV broadcast antennas

MMDS/LMDS antennas $\leq$ 1 meter (wireless cable/internet reception equipment)

Internet or broadband antennas $\leq$ 1 meter

Placement

Where possible, equipment should be placed in rear yard or rear of dwelling where not visible from street.

Equipment may be placed where needed for optimal signal reception, even if visible from the street.

When multiple placement options would provide adequate reception, the least visibly intrusive location is preferred.

Maintenance & Aesthetics

Must be painted/screened to blend in if possible, provided such requirements do not impair reception or impose unreasonable costs.

Must be removed if not in use.

13. Landscaping and Lot Maintenance

Holiday Decorations

Holiday and seasonal decorations are a temporary-display and conduct matter rather than a permanent architectural standard. They are addressed in the Association's Rules & Regulations.

Landscaping Requirements

Landscaping and regular lawn maintenance required.

Street-facing sides must have raised beds with mulch and shrubs.

Lot Cleanliness

Lots must be kept free of debris.

Fill material may only be dumped within 5 days of construction.

Association may charge owners for non-compliance.

Grading

Must follow City-approved plans.

Any changes require city approval.

Maintenance

Homeowners must ensure that all required landscaping (e.g., shrubs, mulch, raised beds) is properly maintained, healthy, and refreshed as necessary to prevent deterioration or a neglected appearance.

14. Vehicle Parking and Storage

Parking Restrictions

Vehicle parking and storage are matters of property use, not architecture. They are governed by Section 9.1.6 of the Declaration and the Association's Rules & Regulations, not by these Design Guidelines.

15. Exterior Lighting and House Numbers

Lighting

Please choose fixtures with moderate brightness appropriate for residential areas.

Light fixtures should be positioned to primarily illuminate your own property.

Be mindful of neighbors when positioning lights to avoid direct illumination into adjacent windows.

House Numbers

Must be visible from the street.

Minimum number height: 4 inches.

Must be in a contrasting color to the background.

16. Exterior Paint and Maintenance

All dwellings must be maintained in good repair.

The Board may require owners to repaint, clean, or make necessary exterior repairs when any of the following conditions are present:

Peeling, chipping, or faded paint covering more than 10% of any exterior surface

Broken, missing, or damaged siding, trim, gutters, or downspouts

Visible rot or damage to wood components

Cracked or damaged masonry

Roof damage or excessive wear

Mold, mildew, or algae growth visible from the street or neighboring properties

17. Flags and Signage

Flags

In accordance with Ohio Revised Code § 5301.072, homeowners have the right to display:

The United States flag

State of Ohio flag

United States armed forces service flags

POW/MIA flag

Flag displays must comply with the U.S. Flag Code (4 U.S.C. §§ 5-10), which includes:

Proper illumination if displayed at night

Respectful handling and display

Proper positioning when displayed with other flags

Flags may be mounted on the home with appropriate brackets or displayed on a freestanding pole not to exceed 20 feet in height.

Signage

Political signs may be displayed during election seasons (90 days before and 10 days after an election).

Signs may not exceed 4 square feet in size.

Real estate "For Sale" signs are permitted but limited to one per property.

Contractor signs may only be displayed while work is actively being performed and must be removed upon completion.

Home security system signs are permitted if modest in size (not exceeding 1 square foot).

18. Accessibility Modifications

Reasonable Accommodations

In compliance with the Fair Housing Act and Ohio law, the Association recognizes homeowners' rights to make reasonable modifications to their property when necessary to afford disabled residents full enjoyment of the premises.

Modifications that would otherwise violate these Design Guidelines may be permitted when needed for accessibility purposes.

Common Examples of Accessibility Modifications:

Ramps for wheelchair access

Widened doorways

Grab bars and handrails

Modified landscaping to accommodate mobility needs

Accessible parking spaces or driveway modifications

Sensory accommodations such as specialized lighting

Submission Process

Homeowners should submit plans for such modifications to the Management Company/Board with the following documentation:

Detailed description of the proposed modification

Professional plans or drawings

Statement of need from a healthcare provider (without disclosing private medical details)

Proposed contractor information if applicable

19. Appeals Process and Dispute Resolution

Appeals Process

An owner whose architectural request is denied may appeal to the full Board under the procedure set out in the Association's Rules & Regulations. That appeal procedure applies only to architectural-review decisions; notice and hearing for fines and individual assessments are governed separately by Section 7.5 of the Declaration.

20. Variance, Discretion, and Modifications to Guidelines

Governing Document Hierarchy

These Design Guidelines are adopted by the Villas at Worthington Homeowners Association, which operates as a planned community under the Ohio Planned Community Act (R.C.5312). These guidelines are subordinate to and must be read in conjunction with the Association's Declaration of Covenants, Conditions, and Restrictions (CC&Rs) and the Bylaws. In the event of a conflict, the CC&Rs and the Bylaws shall control.

Where these Guidelines are silent on a matter, or are less restrictive than the Declaration, the Declaration governs. These Guidelines may impose standards that are equal to or stricter than the Declaration and may address matters on which the Declaration is silent, but they cannot permit what the Declaration prohibits or prohibit what the Declaration permits. Any change requiring those results must be made by amending the Declaration itself under Section 14.2. For any use or improvement not addressed in these Guidelines, owners should consult the Declaration.

Discretion

The elected HOA Board has discretion over guideline interpretations, subject to the appeals process outlined in Section 19.

Variances

May be granted if not detrimental to neighboring lots and in community's best interest.

Precedent from previously granted variances may be considered but does not guarantee approval of similar requests.

Right to Modify

Guidelines may be updated by the Board, provided changes maintain the first-class character of the development.

Any substantial changes to these guidelines will be communicated to all homeowners with at least 30 days notice before implementation.